

DON'T BUY AN EXPENSIVE OLD PROCESS

NEW TECHNOLOGY + **OLD PROCESS** = **EXPENSIVE OLD PROCESS**

Technology doesn't fix a process. It copies it, then runs the copy faster. Rework loops, three versions of the same data, a handoff nobody owns: they all come along. Fix the process first, then automate what is left.

1 Walk the process as it really runs

- Go to the line and follow one unit, form or batch from start to finish.
- Draw what actually happens: workarounds, rework, waits, re-keying.

Trap: Automating the SOP instead of the work as it really happens.

OUTPUT

A current-state map drawn at the gemba, signed by the people who run it.

2 Take out the waste and the variation

- Remove steps that add no value: re-keying, approvals nobody reads, double checks of a check.
- Find why results vary by shift, person or line, and fix the biggest cause.

Trap: Paying a system to do waste faster, and calling it efficiency.

OUTPUT

A shorter process, with the top causes of variation fixed or owned by name.

3 Standardise it and measure a baseline

- Write the best-known way as standard work. Train it. Check it holds.
- Measure the result you want automation to move: time, cost, errors, yield.

Trap: No baseline, so nobody can ever prove the system paid off.

OUTPUT

Standard work in use, and a baseline you trust.

4 Then automate what is left

- Automate the stable steps that are repetitive, rule-based or data-heavy.
- Keep human judgement where the rules run out, and write down who can override.

Trap: Buying the platform first and finding a process to fit it.

OUTPUT

A scoped automation, with the baseline it must beat.

WARNING SIGNS: YOU ARE ABOUT TO AUTOMATE AN OLD PROCESS

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ The vendor demo came before the process walk | ☐ The process has rework loops nobody has counted |
| ☐ The business case has no baseline | ☐ Data is entered in more than one place |
| ☐ Each shift does the job differently | ☐ The people who run it first see it at go-live |

Two or more ticks? Run steps 1 to 3 before you sign the purchase order.



PRE-AUTOMATION CHECK ON ONE PAGE

Fill it in with the people who run the process, before the purchase order. If you can't fill a section, that is the work to do first.

THE PROCESS

THE TECHNOLOGY BEING PROPOSED

1 · WHAT REALLY HAPPENS (FROM THE PROCESS WALK)

STEP	REWORK OR WAIT?	DATA ENTERED WHERE?	OWNER

2 · WASTE AND VARIATION TO REMOVE FIRST

WHAT WE REMOVE OR FIX	OWNER	BY WHEN

3 · BASELINE THE AUTOMATION MUST BEAT

MEASURE	TODAY	TARGET

4 · WHAT STAYS WITH PEOPLE

DECISION	WHO CAN OVERRIDE

READY TO AUTOMATE? ALL FOUR MUST BE YES

CHECK	YES / NO
We walked the process and the map is signed by the people who run it	☐ Yes ☐ No
The biggest waste and variation are removed, or owned with a date	☐ Yes ☐ No
Standard work is in use, and we have a baseline	☐ Yes ☐ No
We know which decisions stay with people, and who can override	☐ Yes ☐ No